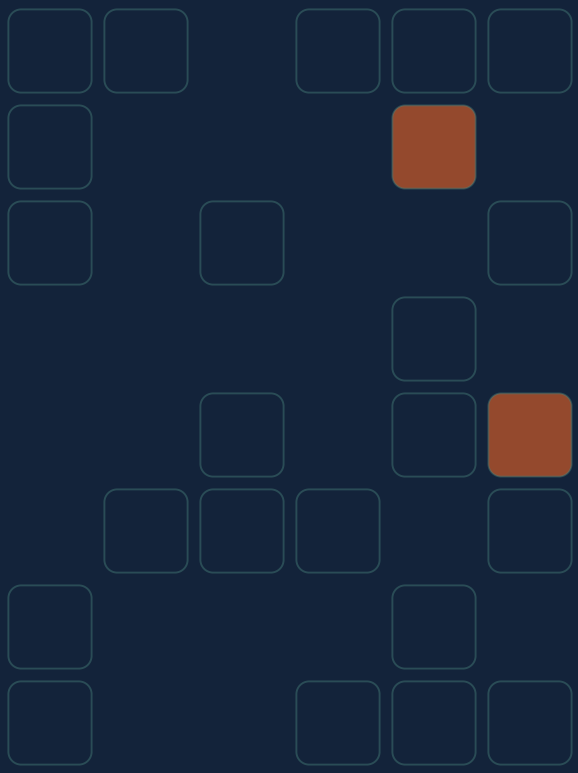
THE LSI TOOLKIT



TOOL 04 OF 04 · FINALIST INTERVIEW GUIDE

LSI Finalist Interview Guide

Structured Interview Process, Question Bank, and Reference Check Guide

learningspaceintegrator.com · Version 2.0 · 2026

Industry Standard Template • Not affiliated with any vendor or proprietary methodology

District Name	[District Name]
Interview Date(s)	[Date(s)]
Location / Format	[In-person / Virtual — platform]
Interview Duration	[60–90 minutes]
Firm Being Interviewed	[Firm Name]
Committee Members Present	[Names and Roles]

LSI TOOLKIT · 04 FINALIST INTERVIEW GUIDE

Interview Purpose and Logistics

Purpose

Finalist interviews let the evaluation committee assess what is hard to judge from a written proposal: how the firm communicates, how the team collaborates, how they think on their feet, and whether the working relationship will be productive.

Interviews are not a second proposal presentation. They are a conversation. The goal is to get beyond polished marketing language to the substance of how the firm actually works.

> All finalist firms are asked the same core questions, in the same order, by the same committee members. This ensures fair comparison. Notes taken during each interview are the record that supports your selection decision.

Anti-Bias and Equal Treatment Requirements

Interview bias is a real and well-documented risk in qualifications-based selection. Committees sometimes score candidates differently based on perceived confidence, communication style, accent, or presentation polish — none of which predict project quality. These requirements are not optional: they protect your district's selection from legal challenge and produce more accurate results.

Required — equal treatment	Do not score or discuss
✓ All firms receive the same advance information: duration, format, committee composition, and general topic areas (not specific questions)	× Body language, eye contact, or nervousness — these reflect communication style, not project capability
✓ The same committee members are present for every finalist interview — no partial attendance or substitutions	× Confidence, charisma, or "presence" — high-confidence presenters are not better consultants

Required — equal treatment	Do not score or discuss
✓ The same questions are asked in the same order for every finalist	× Accent, fluency, or language style — these have no bearing on project outcomes
✓ Each firm gets the same amount of time for each question and for the overall interview	× Personal appearance or dress — assess the team's work, not their presentation
✓ Evaluators score each firm independently and do not discuss scores between interviews	× Impressions formed in the first few minutes — first impressions are frequently biased
✓ The interview scoring weight is established and documented before interviews begin	× Personal connections or prior relationships with the firm or its principals

Before interviews begin, the committee chair should remind all evaluators: **"We are assessing how this team will execute a complex project for our district. Focus your scoring on the substance of what they say — not on how they say it."**

Interview scoring weight: Your committee must establish and document the weight of interview scores relative to written proposal scores before interviews begin. A common approach is written proposal 60–70% and finalist interview 30–40%. This weight cannot change after any interview is conducted.

Logistics

- Invite all finalist firms (typically 2–3) to interview within the same week
- Have the same committee members conduct every finalist interview — no partial attendance
- Assign one person to moderate (keep time and manage questions) and one to take notes
- Give each firm the same advance information: duration, format, who will be in the room, and general topic areas (not specific questions)
- Ask each firm to bring the specific team members who would be assigned to this project
- Do not share scoring results between firm interviews
- Debrief as a full committee after all finalist interviews are complete — not between them

Suggested 90-Minute Agenda

Time	Segment
0–5 min	Introductions: each committee member briefly states name and role
5–15 min	Opening from the firm: 10 minutes to open however they choose
15–60 min	Core interview questions (Sections 1–5)
60–75 min	District-specific scenario or case question (Section 6)

Time	Segment
75–85 min	Firm's questions for the district
85–90 min	Closing and next steps (committee chair explains the timeline)

Section 1: Experience and Track Record

Purpose: Get specific. Generic claims about experience are not useful. You want named projects, real details, and honest reflection.

1. **Walk us through the project you're most proud of. What was the district trying to accomplish, what was your role, and what happened?**
   - What challenges did you face?
   - What would you do differently?
   - What did the space enable that wasn't possible before?

NOTES

2. **Tell us about a project that didn't go as planned. What happened, and how did you handle it?**
   - What did you learn?
   - Would you handle it differently now?

NOTES

3. **Which of your past projects is most similar to what we're asking you to do here? Why?**
   - What's different about our context, and how would you adapt?

NOTES

4. **Can you give us a specific example of a school where the learning environment change had a measurable impact on how teachers taught or students learned?**

- How did you know it was working?
- What data or evidence did you gather?

NOTES

Section 2: Process and Methodology

Purpose: Understand how they actually work, not just how they market their work. Press for specifics.

5 **Walk us through exactly how you would start a project with us. What happens in the first 30 days?**

- Who on your team is involved?
- What would you need from us?
- What decisions would we make together?

NOTES

6 **We have [X] buildings in this project. How would you structure your work to give each building its own focus and accountability?**

- How do you keep learnings from one building from being lost when you move to the next?
- How do you handle it if a building falls behind schedule?

NOTES

7 **How do you help a district figure out what it actually wants before you start designing anything?**

- What does your visioning process look like in practice?
- How long does it take?
- What if district stakeholders disagree?

NOTES

8 **How do you select furniture and technology vendors for a project? Walk us through your process.**

- How do you ensure your recommendations are in the district's best interest?
- If you have financial relationships with vendors, how do you manage that?

NOTES

9 Tell us about a time you had to deliver difficult news to a district — a cost overrun, a delay, or a design decision that didn't work. How did you handle it?

NOTES

Section 3: Accessibility, Inclusion, and Student Voice

Purpose: Understand how the firm thinks about learners who are often underserved by standard design processes. This is not a compliance check — it is an assessment of whether inclusion is embedded in their methodology or treated as an afterthought.

10 **Walk us through how you approach accessibility and universal design in a project. How is it embedded in your process, and at what point does it enter the conversation?**

- Give us a specific example from a past project.
- What does accessibility mean beyond wheelchair ramps and ADA compliance?
- How do you design for sensory differences, neurodiversity, and varied learning needs?

NOTES

11 **How do you include students in the design process — particularly students with disabilities, English learners, and students from historically underserved groups?**

- What does genuine student voice look like in your process, compared with token participation?
- Give us a specific example of a student insight that changed a design decision.

NOTES

12 **How do you measure whether the spaces you design work for all students — not just the majority?**

- What does successful inclusion look like in a completed project?

- How would you know if a space was working well for educators but not for students with disabilities?

NOTES

Section 4: District Alignment and Partnership

Purpose: Assess whether this firm has done its homework on your district and whether you can build a real working relationship.

13 **What do you know about [District Name]? What does our educational vision tell you about what you should prioritize for this project?**

- What questions does it raise for you?
- What assumptions are you making that you'd want to test?

NOTES

14 **How would you describe your working relationship with a district during a typical engagement? Who do you interact with, how often, and what do those interactions look like?**

- What do you expect from us?
- What can we expect from you?

NOTES

15 **Teachers are often skeptical of space redesign projects. How do you build trust with classroom teachers who didn't ask for change?**

- Give us a specific example.

NOTES

16 What would you want us to know about working with your firm that we might not learn from reading your proposal?

NOTES

Section 5: Budget and Fee

Purpose: Confirm transparency and clarify the fee proposal — not to negotiate, but to understand.

17 **Help us understand your fee structure for this project. Walk us through what's included and what's not.**

- How did you arrive at your estimate?
- What would cause the fee to be higher or lower?

NOTES

18 **What happens if we ask for something outside your original scope? How do you handle scope changes?**

- Give us an example from a past project.

NOTES

19 Tell us about a project where the budget was tight. How did you help the district prioritize and manage costs?

NOTES

Section 6: District-Specific Scenario

> Customize this section for each finalist interview. Present a real challenge or context from your district and ask the firm how they would approach it. This is the most valuable part of the interview — it shows you how they think, not just what they know.

Choose **one** of the following formats:

Option A: Open-ended challenge	Option B: Vision-to-space translation
Present a real challenge from your district — a budget constraint, community resistance, a skeptical principal, a building with unusual physical constraints — and ask the firm how they would approach it. **Sample challenge for [District Name]:** [Write 2–3 sentences describing a real, specific challenge you anticipate. For example: "One of our buildings has a very traditional staff culture, and our principal has concerns about whether the space redesign will lead to better outcomes. How would you approach that building?"]	Read your district's educational vision statement (from your RFQ) and ask: "If you were starting tomorrow, what would your first three questions for us be? And based on what you know, what are you most curious about testing or exploring in our spaces?"

What to look for: the quality of their questions, their ability to listen and adapt, how they frame the district's perspective (teacher-centered vs. sales-centered), and honesty about what they don't know.

Notes on scenario response:

NOTES

Reference Check Guide

Complete reference checks on your top 2–3 finalists before or during finalist interviews. Use the same questions for all references to enable fair comparison.

> **Logistics:** Call references directly — do not email unless you must. Identify yourself as a school district evaluating the firm for a project. Most references are willing to be candid if you ask open questions and listen.

Firm Being Checked	[Firm Name]
Reference Name	
Reference Title	
Reference Organization	
Phone / Email	
Date of Call	

Reference Check Questions

1. What was your relationship with this firm? What did they do for you specifically?

NOTES

2. How was it to work with them? (Communication, responsiveness, accessibility of leadership?)

NOTES

3 Did they deliver what they promised — on time and on budget? If there were problems, how did they handle them?

NOTES

4 **How would you describe the outcomes? What changed in how teachers and students used their spaces after the project?**

- Did the result support your instructional goals?
- Were there aspects of the outcome that didn't meet your expectations?

NOTES

5 What would you do differently if you were starting this engagement over again?

NOTES

6 **Would you hire this firm again? Would you recommend them without reservation?**

- Is there anything you'd want another district to know before working with them?

NOTES

Reference Check Summary

Overall impression	
Key strengths heard	
Concerns or cautions	
Recommendation	☐ Advance this firm ☐ Do not advance ☐ Advance with conditions